

The Restaurant Worker's Survival Bundle

6 guides to earn more, protect your peace, and stand up for yourself at work

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- 02** Preventing Burnout in the Restaurant Industry
- 03** How to Document Mistreatment in the Workplace from Management
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How to Increase Your Tips and Income

A server and bartender playbook for bigger checks, better sections, and more money in your pocket every shift

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- The tip formula and the three levers that raise it
- Greeting and table-reading strategies
- Upsell scripts that don't feel pushy
- 30-day growth plan and shift income tracker

01

Proven table-side habits, upsell scripts, and a 30-day income tracker

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CHAPTER 1

Why Some Servers Make More

Two servers can work the same restaurant, the same night, with the same menu, and walk out with very different money. The gap is rarely luck. It usually comes down to a handful of habits you can learn: how you open the table, how you guide the order, how you time the check, and how you make guests feel remembered.

This guide breaks those habits into small steps you can practice one shift at a time. You don't need a new personality or a pushy sales style. The servers who earn the most are usually the ones guests trust.

The tip formula

Most tips follow a simple equation:

$$\text{Tip} = \text{Check Size} \times \text{Tip Percentage} \times \text{Number of Tables You Turn}$$

That gives you three levers to pull:

- **Check size.** Suggest items that make the meal better, like an appetizer, a second drink, or dessert to share.
- **Tip percentage.** Make the experience feel personal, attentive, and easy.
- **Table turns.** Be efficient without rushing people, so you serve more guests in the same shift.

A small change on each lever adds up fast. Raise your average check by \$6, your average tip by 2%, and your table count by one per shift, and you could earn thousands more a year without working extra hours.

Lever	Small improvement	What it could mean over a year*
Average check	+\$6 per table	+\$1,400 to \$2,000
Tip percentage	18% → 20%	+\$1,800 to \$3,000
Table turns	+1 table per shift	+\$2,000 to \$3,500

*Example estimates for a full-time server averaging about 20 tables a shift. Your numbers will vary by restaurant, price point, and schedule.

Try this: Pick just one lever to focus on this week. Trying to fix everything at once usually means nothing sticks.

CHAPTER 2

The First 60 Seconds

Guests decide how they feel about you within the first minute. A warm, confident greeting sets the tone for the whole meal and makes guests more open to your suggestions.

Greet fast, even if you're slammed

Aim to acknowledge every new table within 60 seconds of seating, even if all you can say is a quick hello. A table left waiting and ignored starts the meal irritated. A table told "Hi folks, I'll be right with you!" starts it patient.

A greeting that works

Skip the robotic script. Try this structure instead:

- **Name:** "Hi, I'm Jordan, and I'll be taking care of you tonight."
- **Read the table:** Are they celebrating? Rushed on a lunch break? On a date? Adjust your energy to match.
- **Lead with a suggestion:** "Have you been in before? Our spicy margarita is what everyone's ordering this week."

Reading the table

Table type	What they want	How to serve them
Business lunch	Speed and no interruptions	Get the order in fast, pre-bus quietly, drop the check without being asked
Date night	Privacy and a little romance	Check in less often, suggest a shared dessert, don't linger
Families with kids	Patience and practical help	Bring crayons and kids' cups early, get the kids' food out first
Celebrations	To feel special	Ask what they're celebrating, remember it, add a candle or a personal touch
Regulars	To be remembered	Use their name, remember their usual order, ask about their life
Solo diners	Comfort without pressure	A friendly check-in, a phone charger if you can, never rush them

Try this: Before you approach, take a breath and smile before you arrive at the table, not when you get there. Guests notice.

CHAPTER 3

Upselling Without Being Pushy

Upselling works best when it's a genuine recommendation. You're not pushing product; you're helping guests have a better meal. Guests who order an appetizer, a nicer bottle, or dessert usually enjoy the experience more, and a bigger check usually means a bigger tip.

Suggest specifics, not categories

"Would you like any appetizers?" is easy to say no to. "The crispy calamari with lemon aioli is perfect for sharing while you look at the menu" paints a picture.

Instead of this	Try this
"Anything to drink?"	"Can I start you with our house sangria? It's made fresh every morning."
"Want an appetizer?"	"Our spinach dip comes out fast and it's big enough for the whole table."
"Any dessert?"	"Save room for our lava cake. Should I bring two spoons or four?"
"Another beer?"	"Want me to bring another round so it's here when your food lands?"
"Do you want to add anything?"	"Most people add shrimp to that pasta; it's only \$6 more."

The upgrade ladder

Look for small, natural upgrades at every step of the meal:

- **Drinks:** premium spirits in cocktails, a bottle instead of glasses for 3+ wine drinkers
- **Starters:** a shareable appetizer while they decide
- **Entrées:** add-on proteins, premium sides, sauces
- **Refills:** a second drink offered before the first is empty
- **Dessert:** shared dessert, coffee, after-dinner drinks
- **To-go:** desserts, sauces, or a bottle of house dressing to take home

Know the menu cold

You can't recommend what you haven't tasted. Ask your manager or kitchen if you can try new items. Learn two or three words that describe each dish: "smoky," "bright," "crispy," "rich." Guests trust servers who speak about food with confidence.

Important: Never pressure a guest who has said no, and never upsell alcohol to someone who shows signs of intoxication. Aggressive selling costs you tips and can put your job or license at risk.

CHAPTER 4

Service Habits That Raise Your Tip Percentage

Anticipate needs

The best service feels like mind-reading. Watch for cues and act before the guest has to ask:

- Refill water before the glass is half empty.
- Bring extra napkins with wings, ribs, or anything messy.
- Offer steak knives before the steak arrives.
- Bring hot sauce, ketchup, or extra sauces with the food, not after.
- Clear finished plates promptly, but never while others are still eating.

The two-bite check-back

Check on the table within two bites or two minutes of the food arriving. It's the moment problems show up: wrong temperature, missing side, wrong order. Fixing it fast turns a potential bad tip into a great one.

Personal touches that pay off

- **Use their name** if it's on a reservation or card. "Thank you, Mrs. Garcia."
- **Remember preferences.** "Extra lemon again?" makes regulars feel valued.
- **Crouch down** to eye level when you're talking with seated guests (if it fits your restaurant's culture). It feels friendly rather than hovering.
- **Write a thank-you** on the check, briefly and sincerely. A quick "Thanks so much, enjoy your night!" is enough.
- **Introduce yourself to regulars** and invite them to request your section next time.

Handling mistakes like a pro

Mistakes happen. How you respond decides the tip. Use the **LAST** method:

- **Listen** without interrupting.
- **Apologize** sincerely: "I'm so sorry about that."
- **Solve** it fast: fix the dish, remake the drink, get a manager if needed.
- **Thank** them for telling you.

Guests often tip more after a well-handled mistake than after a meal where nothing went wrong.

CHAPTER 5

Working Smarter, Not Harder

Consolidate every trip

Never walk empty-handed. Every trip to the kitchen or bar is a chance to drop off a check, refill drinks, or clear a plate. "Full hands in, full hands out" is the oldest rule in the book for a reason.

Prioritize like a pro

When everything is happening at once, use this order:

1. Greet new tables (even briefly)
2. Run hot food that's ready
3. Deliver drinks
4. Take orders
5. Drop and process checks
6. Pre-bus and reset

Time the check right

Holding a check too long frustrates guests who want to leave. Dropping it too early makes them feel rushed. Watch for the signals: plates pushed away, jackets being put on, glances around the room. For business lunches and families with young kids, drop the check with dessert or as soon as the last plate is cleared.

Section strategy

- Ask your manager how sections are assigned and what earns you the busier or better sections.
- Consistently high sales, low comps, and reliability are the usual path to better sections.
- Pick up shifts on high-volume nights (Friday and Saturday dinners, holidays, event nights) when you can.
- Learn which shifts actually earn the most by tracking your money (see the tracker at the end).

CHAPTER 6

Growing Your Income Beyond the Tip Line

Build your regulars

Regulars are your financial base. Treat them like VIPs, remember their details, and let them know which shifts you work. A few loyal regulars can guarantee solid nights even when the room is slow.

Stack your skills

Servers who can bartend, train new hires, or run a shift as a lead usually earn more and get more hours. Ask about:

- Bartending shifts or barback training
- Becoming a trainer (often paid a training bonus or higher rate)
- Private events and catering (often have higher auto-gratuity)
- Wine and spirits certifications (Court of Master Sommeliers intro level, WSET Level 1)

Know your pay rights

- In the U.S., if your employer pays a tipped minimum wage, your tips plus base pay must reach at least the full minimum wage for your hours. If they don't, your employer is supposed to make up the difference.
- Managers and supervisors generally are not allowed to keep any part of employees' tips under federal law.
- Tip pools and tip-outs have specific rules that vary by state. Ask for your restaurant's tip policy in writing.
- Keep your own record of hours and tips. It protects you if a pay dispute ever comes up.

Important: Wage and tip laws vary by state and change over time. Check your state labor department's website or the U.S. Department of Labor Wage and Hour Division for current rules where you work.

Manage the money you make

Cash tips disappear fast. A few simple habits help:

- Put a set amount (even \$10 a shift) into savings before you spend anything.
- Track your income for taxes. Tips are taxable income, and good records protect you.
- Plan for slow seasons by saving extra during busy months.

TOOLKIT

Your 30-Day Tip Growth Plan

Work through one focus area per week. Check each box as you practice it.

Week 1: The first impression

- Greet every table within 60 seconds
- Introduce yourself by name at every table
- Recommend one specific drink at every greeting
- Read each table type and adjust your approach

Week 2: Suggestive selling

- Taste or study three menu items you don't know well
- Use specific, descriptive suggestions instead of yes/no questions
- Offer a second drink before the first is empty
- Suggest dessert at every table (with two spoons!)

Week 3: Service polish

- Do the two-bite check-back at every table
- Anticipate one need per table before the guest asks
- Use the LAST method on any complaint
- Never walk to the kitchen empty-handed

Week 4: Build your base

- Learn the names of at least five regulars
- Invite great guests to request your section
- Track every shift in the income tracker
- Ask your manager one question about moving up (sections, training, bartending)

Worksheet: Shift Income Tracker

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TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Monthly Review

My best shift this month (day, time, section):

My average tip percentage:

My average hourly earnings:

The habit that made the biggest difference:

The habit I still need to work on:

My goal for next month:

Regulars I want to remember (names and details):

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You deserve a workplace that respects your time, your effort, and your dignity. Keep this guide close, share what helps, and look out for the people working beside you.

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Preventing Burnout in the Restaurant Industry

How to protect your energy, body, and mental health while working in one of the most demanding jobs there is

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- The 5 stages of restaurant burnout
- Recovery routines for after double shifts
- Boundary scripts for schedules and extra shifts
- Weekly energy planner and self-check worksheets

02

Warning-sign checklists, recovery routines, and a weekly energy planner

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Please note: This guide is for education and self-care support. It is not medical or mental-health treatment. If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or contact local emergency services right away.

CHAPTER 1

Why Restaurant Work Burns People Out

Restaurant work asks a lot from the people who do it. Long shifts on your feet. Late nights followed by early doubles. Unpredictable income. Guests who can be demanding or rude. Short staffing that makes you do two jobs for one paycheck. And through all of it, you're expected to smile.

Burnout isn't a sign that you're weak or that you're not cut out for the industry. It's what happens when the demands on you keep outrunning the time and support you have to recover. The good news: burnout builds in stages, and every stage has off-ramps.

What burnout actually is

Burnout is a state of physical, emotional, and mental exhaustion caused by long-term stress. The World Health Organization describes it in terms of three main features:

- **Exhaustion:** feeling drained, with nothing left to give.
- **Detachment:** feeling cynical, numb, or distant from your job, coworkers, and guests.
- **Reduced effectiveness:** feeling like you can't do your job well anymore, no matter how hard you try.

Why hospitality is uniquely draining

Stress factor	How it wears you down
Emotional labor	Smiling and staying calm while you're stressed, hurt, or disrespected uses real energy
Physical demands	8 to 12 hours standing, carrying, and walking, often without a real break
Irregular schedules	Late closes, "clopens," and changing schedules disrupt sleep and relationships
Income instability	Tip-based pay makes slow nights feel like financial threats
Short staffing	Covering extra tables or roles without extra pay or support
Workplace culture	"Push through it" attitudes, skipped meals, drinking after shifts to decompress

CHAPTER 2

The 5 Stages of Burnout

Burnout doesn't show up overnight. It usually moves through stages. The earlier you notice where you are, the easier it is to turn around.

Stage 1: The honeymoon

You're energized, taking every shift, and proving yourself. It feels great, but you may already be skipping meals, sleeping less, and saying yes to everything.

Off-ramp: Build good habits now, while it's easy: meals, sleep, and at least one real day off a week.

Stage 2: The onset of stress

Some days are harder than others. You notice irritability, trouble sleeping after close, and less patience with guests and coworkers.

Off-ramp: Start a decompression routine after shifts (see Chapter 4). Notice which shifts and situations drain you most.

Stage 3: Chronic stress

Stress is now constant. You may feel tired even after sleep, get sick more often, rely more on caffeine, alcohol, or energy drinks, dread going to work, and snap at people you care about.

Off-ramp: Cut back on extra shifts. Have an honest conversation with your manager about your schedule. Reconnect with life outside work.

Stage 4: Burnout

You feel empty, hopeless about work, and physically worn out. Headaches, stomach problems, or pain may be constant. You might start isolating yourself.

Off-ramp: This is the time to get outside help: a doctor, a counselor, or an employee assistance program if your workplace has one. Consider time off if it's possible.

Stage 5: Habitual burnout

Burnout has become part of your daily life. It may show up as ongoing depression, anxiety, or physical illness.

Off-ramp: Professional support is strongly recommended. A bigger change, such as a different restaurant, a different role, or a break from the industry, may be the healthiest choice.

Important: If you are feeling hopeless or thinking about harming yourself, you are not alone and help is available right now. In the U.S., call or text 988 to reach the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, any time of day.

CHAPTER 3

Self-Check: Where Are You Right Now?

Check every statement that has been true for you in the past two weeks.

Body

- I feel tired even after a full night's sleep
- I have frequent headaches, stomach issues, or muscle pain
- I get sick more often than I used to
- I regularly skip meals during shifts
- I rely on caffeine or energy drinks to get through my day

Mind and emotions

- I dread going to work, even on shifts I used to enjoy
- I feel numb, irritable, or on edge most of the time
- Small problems feel overwhelming
- I have trouble focusing or I make more mistakes than usual
- I feel like nothing I do at work matters

Behavior

- I've pulled away from friends, family, or hobbies
- I drink or use substances more to unwind after shifts
- I call out more often or think about quitting constantly
- I snap at coworkers, guests, or people at home
- I can't stop thinking about work on my days off

What your score means

Checks	What it may mean	Suggested next step
0 to 3	Normal stress levels	Keep your healthy habits going
4 to 7	Early warning signs	Start the recovery routines in this guide this week
8 to 11	Chronic stress	Make schedule changes and talk to someone you trust
12 to 15	Possible burnout	Reach out to a doctor or counselor and prioritize rest

This self-check is a reflection tool, not a diagnosis.

CHAPTER 4

Recovery Routines That Actually Fit a Server's Life

Standard wellness advice often assumes a 9-to-5 schedule. These routines are built for people who get off at midnight and work doubles.

The post-shift decompression (20 minutes)

Getting home wired at 1 a.m. and scrolling your phone until 4 a.m. is one of the fastest routes to exhaustion. Try this instead:

1. **Transition ritual (5 min):** Change out of your work clothes, wash your face, and put your apron and tips away. It signals to your brain that the shift is over.
2. **Refuel (5 min):** Eat something with protein, even if it's small. Drink water.
3. **Brain dump (5 min):** Write down anything bugging you from the shift, then close the notebook.
4. **Wind down (5 min):** Stretch, take a hot shower, or do slow breathing. Dim the lights and put your phone down.

Protect your sleep

- Aim for a consistent sleep window, even on days off, as much as your schedule allows.
- Use blackout curtains and an eye mask if you sleep during daylight hours.
- Cut caffeine at least 6 hours before you plan to sleep.
- Keep alcohol as an occasional choice, not a nightly sleep aid. It disrupts deep sleep.

Take care of your body on the floor

- **Shoes:** Invest in slip-resistant, supportive work shoes and replace them when the support wears out.
- **Compression socks:** They can reduce leg fatigue and swelling on long shifts.
- **Hydration:** Keep a water cup at the service station and actually drink from it.
- **Fuel:** Eat before your shift starts. A protein bar in your apron beats nothing.
- **Stretch:** Calves, hips, and lower back. Two minutes before and after a shift makes a difference.

Your off days are for recovery

- Schedule at least one day each week with no work obligations at all.
- Do at least one thing that has nothing to do with restaurants: a hobby, time outside, a class, a friend.
- Mute work group chats on your days off if you can.

Try this: The "3 R's" for your day off: **Rest** (sleep in), **Reconnect** (see someone you care about), **Recharge** (do one thing just for fun).

CHAPTER 5

Setting Boundaries at Work

Boundaries aren't about being difficult. They're about staying healthy enough to keep doing your job well.

Know your limits before you're asked

Decide ahead of time how many shifts a week you can work before your health starts to suffer. When a request comes in, you already know your answer.

Scripts for common situations

Situation	What you can say
Asked to pick up an extra shift	"I can't this time, but I'm glad to help another week."
Asked to stay late again	"I can stay 30 more minutes, but then I need to head out."
Texted on your day off	Reply later, when you're ready: "Just seeing this. I'm not available today."
Getting overloaded with tables	"I'm at capacity. Can we seat the next table with someone else so I don't drop service?"
Skipping breaks	"I need to take my break now. Can you cover my section for 15 minutes?"

You're allowed to say no

- "No" is a complete sentence. You don't owe a long explanation.
- You can be a team player and still protect your time off.
- If saying no to extra shifts leads to punishment, such as losing regular shifts, being treated differently, or being threatened, write it down. See Guide 03 in this series for how to document it.

Know your break and scheduling rights

Break and scheduling laws vary a lot by state and city. Some states require meal and rest breaks; others don't. Some cities have "fair workweek" laws that require advance notice of schedules. Check your state labor department's website for the rules where you work.

CHAPTER 6

Money Stress and Burnout

Unpredictable income is one of the biggest hidden drivers of burnout in hospitality. When every slow night feels like an emergency, it's hard to ever rest.

Build a buffer

- **Track your average.** Know your typical weekly income so you can plan around it (see Guide 01's income tracker).
- **Budget for your slow weeks, not your best weeks.**
- **Start a small emergency fund.** Even \$300 to \$500 can take the panic out of a slow week.
- **Automate savings.** Deposit a fixed portion of every shift's tips before you spend.

Stop trading your health for extra shifts

Extra shifts are sometimes necessary, but notice the pattern. If you're picking up shifts every week just to stay afloat, it may be time to look at your rate, your section, your restaurant, or your role. The fix may be a better-paying position, not more hours.

CHAPTER 7

When It's Time for Bigger Changes

Sometimes recovery isn't enough, because the problem is the job itself.

Signs your workplace is the problem

- Burnout is widespread among your coworkers, not just you.
- Management ignores repeated concerns about staffing, safety, or treatment.
- You're consistently denied breaks, time off, or fair scheduling.
- You're harassed, disrespected, or treated unfairly (see Guides 03 and 06).

Options to consider

- **Talk to management** about specific changes: fewer doubles, a different section, a set day off.
- **Change roles:** host, bartender, trainer, events, or catering can have different stress patterns.
- **Change restaurants:** a healthier culture can make a huge difference with the same job.
- **Take a break:** if you can afford it, time away can reset your body and mind.
- **Get support:** a therapist, doctor, or an employee assistance program (EAP) if your job offers one.

Free support resources (U.S.)

- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988, any time.
- **SAMHSA National Helpline:** 1-800-662-4357 for free, confidential treatment referrals for mental-health and substance-use concerns.
- **Your doctor or a community health center** for physical symptoms of stress.
- **Industry nonprofits** such as Ben's Friends (support for food and beverage workers in recovery) and Southern Smoke Foundation (emergency relief and mental-health access for food and beverage workers in eligible areas).

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Weekly Energy Planner

Plan your week around your energy, not just your schedule.

Day	Shift(s)	Energy (1 to 5)	Recovery activity	Did I eat and hydrate?
Monday				
Tuesday				
Wednesday				
Thursday				
Friday				
Saturday				
Sunday				

My maximum number of shifts this week:

My protected day off:

One thing I'm doing just for me this week:

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Burnout Prevention Plan

The situations that drain me the most at work:

My early warning signs (how I know I'm getting worn down):

My go-to recovery routine after a hard shift:

Boundaries I will protect (shifts, days off, breaks, texts):

People I can talk to when I'm struggling:

If things get worse, my next step will be:

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How to Document Mistreatment in the Workplace from Management

A step-by-step guide for restaurant workers to record what's happening, protect themselves, and know where to turn

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- What to document and what counts as mistreatment
- How to write an incident note that holds up
- Safe ways to store evidence
- Printable incident log, timeline, and complaint templates

03

Incident log templates, a written-complaint template, and a reporting roadmap

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Please note: This guide is general education, not legal advice. Employment laws vary by country, state, and city, and deadlines apply. For advice about your specific situation, talk to an employment attorney, a legal aid organization, or the government agency that handles your issue.

CHAPTER 1

Why Documentation Matters

When a manager mistreats you, it can feel like your word against theirs. Managers often have more power, more access to records, and more credibility with owners or HR. Documentation helps balance that.

Clear, consistent records can:

- **Show a pattern.** One comment might be brushed off. Fifteen dated incidents are much harder to ignore.
- **Protect your memory.** Stress blurs details. Notes written the same day stay accurate.
- **Support a complaint.** HR, owners, government agencies, and attorneys all rely on evidence.
- **Protect you from retaliation.** If you're suddenly written up, cut from the schedule, or fired after complaining, a record of what happened before and after matters.
- **Help you think clearly.** Seeing everything on paper can help you decide what to do next.

Try this: Start documenting now, even if you're not sure you'll ever report anything. You can always decide not to use your notes. You can't go back and create accurate notes later.

CHAPTER 2

What Counts as Mistreatment?

Not every bad manager is breaking the law, but mistreatment is worth documenting either way. Here's a general overview of common issues in restaurants.

Issues that may be illegal (U.S.)

Type	Examples	Who usually handles it
Discrimination	Worse shifts, sections, pay, or discipline because of race, color, religion, sex (including pregnancy, sexual orientation, and gender identity), national origin, age (40+), disability, or genetic information	EEOC or your state fair employment agency
Harassment	Offensive jokes, slurs, unwanted touching, sexual comments, or demands tied to a protected characteristic	EEOC or state agency
Retaliation	Punishment for reporting discrimination or harassment, filing a complaint, or supporting a coworker's complaint	EEOC, DOL, OSHA, or NLRB (depends on the issue)
Wage and tip violations	Unpaid hours, off-the-clock work, managers taking tips, not making up the minimum wage, missing overtime	U.S. Department of Labor Wage and Hour Division or your state labor department
Unsafe conditions	Broken equipment, blocked exits, burns or injuries ignored, no protection from hazards	OSHA or your state safety agency
Punishment for discussing pay or conditions	Being disciplined for talking with coworkers about wages, tips, schedules, or treatment	National Labor Relations Board (NLRB)

Issues that may not be illegal, but still matter

- Yelling, belittling, or humiliating you in front of others
- Unfair scheduling or section assignments with no clear reason
- Playing favorites, gossip, or excluding you (see Guide 06)
- Constant criticism with no support to improve

- Ignoring your concerns or complaints

These may break company policy even when they don't break the law. They may also be part of a larger pattern that *does* connect to a protected characteristic or to retaliation. Document them.

CHAPTER 3

How to Write an Incident Note

A good incident note is **specific, factual, and written as soon as possible**. Think like a reporter, not a diary.

The 7 things every note should include

1. **Date and time** the incident happened, plus when you're writing the note.
2. **Location:** the dining room, the kitchen, the office, a text message, a phone call.
3. **Who was involved:** full names and job titles.
4. **What happened:** exactly what was said or done, in order. Use direct quotes when you can.
5. **Witnesses:** anyone who saw or heard it, even if you're not sure they'd speak up.
6. **How you responded:** what you said or did.
7. **The impact:** lost shifts, lost pay, a write-up, physical effects, emotional distress.

Facts vs. feelings

Your feelings are valid, but notes are strongest when they lead with facts. Add how it affected you at the end.

Weaker	Stronger
"My manager was really rude to me again."	"At 7:40 p.m. on 3/14, at the expo line, Manager Chris Lee said, 'You're useless, just get out of my sight,' in front of Maria Gomez (server) and Tony Park (line cook)."
"She always gives me the worst sections."	"For the past 4 weeks (dates attached), I was assigned the patio section every Friday and Saturday while coworkers with less seniority got main-floor sections. I asked why on 3/10 and was told 'That's just how it is.'"
"They cut my hours because I complained."	"I emailed HR about harassment on 2/2. My schedule for the weeks of 2/9 and 2/16 dropped from 5 shifts to 2. No reason was given."

Example incident note

Date/time of incident: Friday, March 14, about 7:40 p.m.

Date/time written: Friday, March 14, 11:55 p.m.

Location: Expo line, main kitchen

People involved: Chris Lee (General Manager)

What happened: When I picked up food for table 12, Chris said, "You're useless, just get out of my sight." He said it loudly. He then took the plates out of my hands and gave them to another server.

Witnesses: Maria Gomez (server), Tony Park (line cook)

My response: I said, "Please don't speak to me like that," and went back to my section.

Impact: I was embarrassed in front of coworkers and had trouble focusing for the rest of my shift. This is the third incident this month (see notes from 3/2 and 3/8).

Important: Write only what you know. If you're guessing why something happened, label it: "I believe this was because..." Never exaggerate or add details you're unsure of. Accuracy is what makes your records credible.

CHAPTER 4

Collecting and Storing Evidence Safely

What to save

- **Your incident notes**, written the same day
- **Text messages, emails, and group chat messages** (screenshots showing the date, time, and sender)
- **Schedules**, especially before and after changes (photos or screenshots)
- **Pay stubs, tip reports, and your own record of hours and tips**
- **Write-ups or performance reviews**, and your written response to them
- **Photos** of unsafe conditions or injuries
- **Medical records** if you were injured or saw a doctor for stress-related symptoms
- **The employee handbook** or any policy you were given

Where to keep it

- Keep records **somewhere your employer can't access or delete**: a personal notebook kept at home, a personal email account, or personal cloud storage.
- **Don't use work computers, work email, or company-owned phones** for your documentation.
- One simple method: email each incident note to yourself from your personal account. It creates an automatic timestamp.
- Back up screenshots in more than one place.

What NOT to take

- **Don't take confidential company documents**, customer information, or anything you weren't given access to. Doing so may violate policy or the law and can hurt your case.
- **Don't access someone else's account, phone, or files.**

A note about recording conversations

Recording laws vary by state. Some states allow you to record a conversation you're part of without telling anyone. Others require **everyone** in the conversation to agree. Recording illegally can create legal problems for you, and your employer may also have its own policies. **Check your state's law before recording anything**, and when in doubt, write detailed notes right after the conversation instead.

CHAPTER 5

Reporting Inside Your Workplace

In many situations, reporting internally first is an important step, both to give the company a chance to fix the problem and because it may matter later if you file an outside complaint.

Before you report

- Read the employee handbook for the complaint or grievance process.
- Identify the right person: HR, the owner, a regional or district manager, or a manager above the one involved.
- Gather your documentation and decide what outcome you're asking for.

Put it in writing

A verbal complaint can be forgotten or denied. A written complaint creates a record. After any in-person meeting, send a short follow-up email summarizing what was discussed.

Written complaint template

Subject: Formal complaint regarding [manager's name]

Dear [HR / Owner name],

I am writing to formally report ongoing concerns about how I am being treated by [name, title]. I am asking that this complaint be investigated and kept as confidential as possible.

On [date], [brief factual description]. On [date], [brief factual description]. [Add more as needed or attach your incident log.]

These incidents have affected me by [lost shifts, reduced income, stress, etc.]. I believe this treatment may be related to [my race / my pregnancy / my complaint on (date) / etc., only if you believe this is true].

I am requesting [an investigation / a change in who supervises me / a meeting to discuss / a return to my previous schedule]. I would also like confirmation that I will not be retaliated against for making this report.

Please confirm you have received this complaint. I can be reached at [phone / personal email].

Sincerely,

[Your name, position, date]

Try this: Keep a copy of every complaint you send and every reply you receive. If you meet in person, write down who attended and what was said as soon as the meeting ends.

After you report: watch for retaliation

Retaliation can look like: suddenly worse sections, fewer shifts, sudden write-ups, being excluded, or being fired. Keep documenting after you report, because changes in treatment after a complaint are important evidence.

CHAPTER 6

Reporting Outside Your Workplace (U.S.)

If reporting internally doesn't work, isn't safe, or doesn't apply, government agencies may be able to help. Many have **strict deadlines**, so don't wait too long.

Agency	What they handle	Typical deadline to file*	Contact
EEOC (Equal Employment Opportunity Commission)	Discrimination, harassment, and related retaliation	180 days, extended to 300 days in many states	eeoc.gov · 1-800-669-4000
DOL Wage and Hour Division	Unpaid wages, tips, overtime, minimum wage	Generally 2 years (3 if willful) for many wage claims	dol.gov/agencies/whd · 1-866-487-9243
OSHA	Unsafe conditions; retaliation for safety complaints	Retaliation complaints: 30 days	osha.gov · 1-800-321-6742
NLRB (National Labor Relations Board)	Punishment for discussing pay or conditions with coworkers or acting together	6 months	nlr.gov · 1-844-762-6572
Your state labor or civil rights agency	State wage, break, and anti-discrimination laws (often broader than federal law)	Varies by state	Search "[your state] labor department"

*Deadlines summarized for general education and can change. Confirm the current deadline with the agency or an attorney as soon as possible.

Talking to an attorney

- Many employment attorneys offer **free consultations** and some work on contingency (paid only if you win).
- Legal aid organizations and law school clinics may help for free if you qualify.
- Bring your incident log, timeline, pay records, and any complaints you've filed.

CHAPTER 7

Taking Care of Yourself Through It

Documenting mistreatment means reliving hard experiences. That takes a toll.

- **Limit the time you spend on it.** Write the note, then close the notebook.
- **Talk to someone you trust:** a friend, family member, or counselor.
- **Keep your job performance steady** as much as you can, so there's no legitimate reason to discipline you.
- **Stay professional in writing.** Assume anything you text or email could be read by others later.
- **Plan for your future.** It's okay to look for a new job while you document. Your well-being comes first.

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Incident Log

Make copies of this page. Use one row per incident and attach detailed notes when needed.

Date / Time	Location	Who was involved	What happened (facts and quotes)	Witnesses	Impact

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Detailed Incident Report

Date and time of incident:

Date and time this note was written:

Location:

People involved (names and titles):

What happened (in order, using exact words when possible):

Witnesses:

How I responded:

Impact on me (pay, schedule, health, emotions):

Evidence saved (screenshots, schedules, photos):

Related past incidents (dates):

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Timeline and Contacts

Timeline of key events

Record major events in order: incidents, complaints you made, responses, schedule or pay changes, discipline.

Date	Event	Evidence I have

Reports and complaints I've made

Date	Reported to (name / agency)	How (email, meeting, form)	Response received

Documentation checklist

- I keep my notes outside of work systems
- I write notes the same day as each incident
- I've saved relevant texts, emails, and schedules
- I have copies of my pay stubs and my own hours and tips log
- I have a copy of the employee handbook
- I've checked my state's recording law before recording anything
- I've reported in writing and kept a copy
- I know the deadlines for any outside agency I may contact

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Essential Skills Every Front-of-House Worker Needs

The complete skills guide for servers, hosts, bartenders, and bussers, from your first shift to shift lead

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- The 12 core front-of-house skills
- Steps of service and table maintenance standards
- Handling allergies, alcohol, and difficult guests
- Skills self-assessment and growth plan

04

Skill checklists, service standards, and a self-assessment to plan your growth

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CHAPTER 1

What Great Front-of-House Workers Have in Common

Front of house (FOH) is the part of the restaurant guests see: hosts, servers, bartenders, bussers, food runners, and managers. The kitchen makes the food, but FOH makes the experience.

The best FOH workers aren't just friendly. They're organized, calm under pressure, and always two steps ahead. Every one of those skills can be learned.

The 12 core skills

Skill	Why it matters
1. Hospitality mindset	Guests remember how you made them feel more than what they ate
2. Communication	Clear words with guests, kitchen, and team prevent mistakes
3. Menu knowledge	Confident recommendations increase sales and trust
4. Multitasking and prioritizing	Busy shifts require juggling many tables at once
5. Time management	Timing courses, checks, and side work keeps the room running
6. Memory and attention to detail	Orders, allergies, and preferences must be right
7. Teamwork	Restaurants run on people helping each other
8. Problem-solving	Things go wrong every shift; how you fix them matters
9. Staying calm under pressure	Stress spreads, and so does calm
10. Food safety and allergy awareness	Guest health depends on it
11. Responsible alcohol service	Protects guests, you, and the restaurant's license
12. POS and cash handling	Accuracy protects your money and your job

CHAPTER 2

The Hospitality Mindset

Service is doing your job. Hospitality is making people feel cared for while you do it.

Service vs. hospitality

Service	Hospitality
Bringing the food on time	Noticing a guest is cold and offering a table away from the door
Taking the order correctly	Remembering a regular's usual and asking about their kid's game
Answering questions	Offering a sample when a guest can't decide
Dropping the check	Thanking the guest by name and inviting them back

Habits of hospitality

- **Make eye contact and smile** at every guest you pass, not just the ones in your section.
- **Say yes when you can.** Look for ways to meet requests before saying no.
- **Own the guest's experience.** If you see a problem at any table, help or get help.
- **Stay genuine.** Guests can tell when you're following a script without meaning it.

CHAPTER 3

The Steps of Service

Most restaurants follow a version of these steps. Learn your restaurant's specific standards, but this framework works almost anywhere.

1. **Greet** within 60 seconds of seating. Introduce yourself and offer drinks.
2. **Deliver drinks** and take appetizer orders. Share specials.
3. **Take the order.** Repeat back tricky orders, and ask about allergies.
4. **Enter the order** into the POS right away, with accurate modifiers.
5. **Deliver food** with a description ("Here's your salmon with lemon butter"), and place plates in the right position.
6. **Check back** within two bites or two minutes.
7. **Maintain the table:** refills, clearing, fresh silverware.
8. **Offer dessert and after-dinner drinks.**
9. **Present the check** at the right time, and process payment promptly.
10. **Thank and farewell:** invite guests back.

Table maintenance standards

- Water glasses refilled before they're half empty
- Empty glasses and plates cleared promptly (once everyone at the table is finished)
- Used silverware replaced before the next course
- Crumbs and spills cleaned between courses
- Condiments and extra napkins brought before the guest needs to ask
- Table is never left without a check-in for too long

CHAPTER 4

Communication Skills

With guests

- **Speak clearly** and adjust your volume to the room.
- **Listen fully** before answering. Repeat back orders with modifications.
- **Use positive language:** say "What I can do is..." instead of "We can't."
- **Read body language:** crossed arms, looking around, or pushed-away plates all tell you something.

With the kitchen

- Enter orders accurately and completely. The kitchen can only make what's on the ticket.
- Use your restaurant's terms ("on the fly," "86'd," "all day," "behind") correctly.
- Communicate allergies clearly and directly, in person as well as in the system when that's your restaurant's policy.
- Be respectful, even when things are hectic. The kitchen is your partner.

With your team

- Call out "behind," "corner," and "hot" when moving through the restaurant.
- Tell teammates when you need help, and offer help when you see someone drowning.
- Hand off tables with clear notes: what's been ordered, what's pending, any special requests.

Common restaurant terms

Term	Meaning
86'd	Out of an item; it's no longer available
On the fly	Needed as fast as possible
All day	Total count of an item needed across all orders
In the weeds	Overwhelmed and behind
Behind / Corner / Hot	Safety call-outs to avoid collisions
Campers	Guests who stay long after finishing
Comp	An item given for free
Double / Clopen	Two shifts in one day / closing then opening the next morning
Expo	The person or station that checks and sends food out
Top	Number of guests at a table ("a four-top")

CHAPTER 5

Menu Knowledge and Selling

Know every item

- Main ingredients and preparation (fried, grilled, raw, etc.)
- Common allergens (see the table in the next chapter)
- Portion sizes and what's good to share
- What can and can't be modified
- Two or three descriptive words for every item

Know the drinks

- House cocktails and what's in them
- Beer on tap and what styles they are
- Wines by the glass and what they pair with
- Non-alcoholic options and mocktails

Try this: Make menu flashcards. Put the dish name on one side and ingredients, allergens, and your go-to description on the other. Study five a day.

For upselling scripts and more sales techniques, see Guide 01 in this series.

CHAPTER 6

Food Safety and Allergy Awareness

Allergy awareness is non-negotiable

Food allergies can be life-threatening. In the U.S., the major food allergens are:

Major allergen	Common sources on menus
Milk	Butter, cheese, cream sauces, some breads
Eggs	Aioli, mayonnaise, batters, pasta, baked goods
Fish	Fish sauce, Caesar dressing, Worcestershire
Shellfish	Shrimp, crab, lobster, some stocks
Tree nuts	Pesto, desserts, some sauces and oils
Peanuts	Sauces, dressings, desserts, fryer oils
Wheat	Breads, batters, pasta, soy sauce, thickened sauces
Soy	Soy sauce, tofu, many processed ingredients
Sesame	Buns, dressings, tahini, hummus

The allergy protocol

1. **Ask** every table if anyone has allergies.
2. **Listen** carefully and write it down.
3. **Check** with the kitchen or manager. Never guess about ingredients.
4. **Communicate** the allergy clearly on the ticket and in person, following restaurant policy.
5. **Deliver** allergy meals separately if you can, confirming with the guest.

Important: Never tell a guest a dish is "safe" if you aren't completely sure. "Let me check with the kitchen" is always the right answer.

Basic food safety for FOH

- Wash your hands often, especially after clearing plates, handling cash, or touching your face or phone.
- Hold plates by the edges and glasses by the stem or base, never by the rim.

- Don't touch ice or ready-to-eat food with bare hands; use scoops and tongs.
- Report spills immediately and clean them up to prevent slips.

CHAPTER 7

Responsible Alcohol Service

If you serve alcohol, you're responsible for serving it legally and safely.

- **Check ID** for anyone who looks under the age your restaurant's policy sets (often 30 or 40). Know what a valid ID looks like in your state.
- **Watch for signs of intoxication:** slurred speech, loud or aggressive behavior, stumbling, spilling drinks.
- **Slow down service** by offering water and food, and taking longer between rounds.
- **Involve a manager** before cutting someone off, and do it privately and respectfully.
- **Never serve** a visibly intoxicated guest or a minor.

Many states require or encourage alcohol server training such as ServSafe Alcohol or TIPS. It's a valuable certification even if your state doesn't require it.

CHAPTER 8

Handling Difficult Situations

Difficult guests

Use the **HEARD** method:

- **Hear** the guest out fully without interrupting.
- **Empathize**: "I understand how frustrating that must be."
- **Apologize** sincerely, even if it isn't your fault.
- **Resolve** the issue quickly, or get a manager.
- **Diagnose** afterwards: what caused it, and how can you prevent it next time?

When to get a manager right away

- A guest is aggressive, threatening, or harassing you or others
- There's a food allergy reaction or medical emergency
- A guest wants something only a manager can approve (large comps, policy exceptions)
- A guest is visibly intoxicated or a minor is trying to order alcohol
- You feel unsafe for any reason

Important: You never have to tolerate harassment or threats from guests. Tell a manager. If you're being mistreated by management, see Guide 03.

Staying calm under pressure

- **Breathe**: a slow breath in for 4 counts and out for 6 resets your nervous system in seconds.
- **Prioritize**: use the priority order from Guide 01 to decide what's next.
- **Ask for help early**, before you're drowning.
- **Take it one table at a time**. You can't fix the whole room at once.

CHAPTER 9

POS, Payments, and Cash Handling

- Enter orders and modifiers carefully. Double-check before you send.
- Never leave your server login open. Log out every time.
- Count your cash bank at the start and end of each shift.
- Present change and receipts accurately and politely.
- Follow your restaurant's rules for voids and comps. Always get approval.
- Keep your own record of tips and sales (see the tracker in Guide 01).

CHAPTER 10

Growing Your Career

FOH skills can lead to many roles:

Role	Skills to build
Host → Server	Menu knowledge, table management, sales
Server → Bartender	Drink knowledge, speed, multitasking
Server → Trainer	Communication, patience, service standards
Trainer → Shift lead / Supervisor	Leadership, conflict resolution, scheduling
Supervisor → Manager	Finances, hiring, operations, labor laws

Certifications that add value

- **Food handler card** (required in many states and counties)
- **ServSafe Alcohol** or **TIPS** (responsible alcohol service)
- **ServSafe Food Protection Manager** (for supervisory roles)
- **Wine and spirits courses** (such as WSET Level 1 or introductory sommelier courses)

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Skills Self-Assessment

Rate yourself honestly from 1 (need a lot of work) to 5 (I could train others on this).

Skill	Rating (1 to 5)	One thing I can practice this month
Hospitality mindset		
Communication		
Menu knowledge		
Multitasking and prioritizing		
Time management		
Memory and attention to detail		
Teamwork		
Problem-solving		
Staying calm under pressure		
Food safety and allergy awareness		
Responsible alcohol service		
POS and cash handling		

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Growth Plan

My top 3 strengths:

The 3 skills I want to improve most:

Certifications I want to earn (and by when):

The role I want in 1 year:

What I'll ask my manager to help me get there:

My first step this week:

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Restaurant Communication and Workplace Conflict

How to speak up, handle tension, and resolve conflict with coworkers, the kitchen, and management without losing your cool or your job

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- Why conflict happens in restaurants
- Communication styles and how to adapt
- Scripts for coworkers, the kitchen, and managers
- Conflict resolution planner and reflection worksheets

05

Conversation scripts, de-escalation tools, and conflict planning worksheets

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CHAPTER 1

Why Restaurants Are Conflict Hot Spots

Restaurants put a lot of people in a small, hot, loud space under constant time pressure. Everyone depends on everyone else, and money depends on the whole team performing. It's no surprise tempers flare.

Common sources of conflict

Source	What it looks like
Pressure and speed	Snapping at each other during a rush
FOH vs. BOH tension	Servers blaming the kitchen for slow food; cooks blaming servers for wrong tickets
Uneven workloads	Some people doing more side work, getting more tables, or covering more shifts
Money	Tip pools, tip-outs, and section assignments that feel unfair
Scheduling	Favoritism, last-minute changes, shift swaps gone wrong
Personalities and gossip	Cliques, rumors, and personal drama spilling into work
Poor communication	Unclear expectations, assumptions, and things "lost in translation"

Conflict isn't always bad. Handled well, it can fix real problems, like an unfair side work system or a broken ticket process. Handled badly, it poisons the whole team.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding Communication Styles

Most people lean toward one of four styles. Knowing yours, and recognizing others', makes conflict easier to navigate.

Style	What it looks like	The effect
Passive	Staying quiet, avoiding conflict, going along to keep the peace	Resentment builds; problems don't get fixed
Aggressive	Yelling, blaming, interrupting, intimidating	People get defensive or shut down
Passive-aggressive	Sarcasm, silent treatment, gossip, "forgetting" on purpose	Trust breaks down; tension lingers
Assertive	Stating needs clearly and respectfully while listening to others	Problems get solved; respect grows

The goal: assertive communication

Assertive communication means being honest about what you need while respecting the other person. It sounds like:

- "I need..." instead of "You never..."
- "I noticed..." instead of "You always..."
- "Can we figure out..." instead of "This is your fault."

The "I" statement formula

When [specific situation], **I feel** [emotion], **because** [impact]. **Could we** [request]?

Example: "When my tickets get fired late, I feel stressed, because my tables wait and my tips drop. Could we go over the timing process together before tomorrow's shift?"

CHAPTER 3

Communicating Under Pressure

The middle of a rush is the worst time for a deep conversation, but the most common time for conflict.

During the rush

- **Keep it short and specific.** "I need table 12's salmon re-fired, no butter, allergy."
- **Stay neutral.** Tone matters more than words when everyone's stressed.
- **Save the bigger conversation** for later: "Can we talk about this after the rush?"
- **Don't take the heat personally.** Someone snapping in the weeds often isn't about you.

Take a pause before responding

When you feel your temper rising, try **STOP**:

- **Stop** what you're about to say.
- **Take** a breath, or two.
- **Observe** what's actually happening and how you're feeling.
- **Proceed** with a calm, intentional response.

Try this: If you need to, step away for 30 seconds: check the walk-in, refill ice, or take a quick breather. It's better than saying something you'll regret.

CHAPTER 4

FOH and BOH: Working with the Kitchen

The front and back of house often see the same problem from opposite sides. Building a good relationship with the kitchen makes every shift easier.

What the kitchen wishes servers knew

- A ticket with missing modifiers or allergies creates problems that are hard to fix mid-rush.
- "Where's my food?" every two minutes slows them down.
- Ringing in orders all at once creates bottlenecks.
- A "thank you" at the end of the night goes a long way.

What servers wish the kitchen knew

- Guests blame the server for slow or wrong food, and it hits our tips.
- We're often relaying guest requests we don't control.
- A quick heads-up about 86'd items or delays helps us manage guests.

Building a better relationship

- Learn the cooks' names and treat them with respect.
- Ask questions about dishes when it's slow, not during a rush.
- Own your mistakes: "That was my ticket error, sorry. Can you re-fire it?"
- Share positive guest feedback with the kitchen.

CHAPTER 5

Conflict with Coworkers

Before you address it, ask yourself

- Is this a one-time thing or a pattern?
- Could there be a misunderstanding?
- What outcome do I actually want?
- Is this something I can handle directly, or do I need a manager?

The 5-step conversation

1. **Pick the right time and place:** private, calm, not during service.
2. **Open with respect:** "Hey, do you have a few minutes to talk about something?"
3. **Describe, don't accuse:** use "I" statements and specific examples.
4. **Listen to their side** without interrupting. Ask questions.
5. **Agree on a solution** you can both live with, and follow up.

Scripts for common situations

Situation	What you can say
A coworker skips side work	"I've noticed the side work list hasn't been done on our shared closes. Can we split it up so it's fair?"
Someone steals your tables	"I think table 9 was mine per the seating chart. Can we check with the host so we're on the same page?"
A coworker is rude to you	"I didn't love how that came across earlier. I'd rather we talk to each other with respect, even when it's busy."
Someone gossips about you	"I heard some things were said about me. I'd rather you come to me directly if there's a problem."
A shift swap falls through	"We agreed on the swap for Saturday, and it didn't happen. Can we confirm swaps in writing going forward?"
Tip-out disagreements	"Can we look at the tip-out sheet together? I want to make sure I understand how it was calculated."

Important: If a coworker's behavior involves harassment, threats, discrimination, or violence, don't try to handle it alone. Report it to a manager or HR, and document it (see Guide 03).

CHAPTER 6

Conflict with Management

Disagreeing with a manager can feel risky. Done well, it can build respect and solve real problems.

Tips for talking to a manager

- **Ask for a private meeting** at a calm time: "Do you have 10 minutes before the shift?"
- **Come prepared** with specifics: dates, examples, and a suggested solution.
- **Focus on the business impact:** "When I'm triple-sat without a busser, service slows and guests complain."
- **Stay professional**, even if they don't.
- **Follow up in writing:** "Thanks for meeting today. Just to recap, we agreed that..."

Scripts for common manager conversations

Situation	What you can say
Unfair scheduling	"I've noticed my shifts dropped over the past three weeks. Can you help me understand why, and what I can do to get more hours?"
Being corrected in front of guests	"I want to fix mistakes, and I'm open to feedback. Could we have those conversations privately?"
Unclear expectations	"I want to make sure I'm meeting your standards. Could you walk me through what you're looking for on closes?"
Asking for help during a rush	"I'm at capacity and my tables are waiting. Can you help run food or seat the next party elsewhere?"
Receiving a write-up you disagree with	"I'd like to add my written response to this before I sign it."

When a conversation isn't enough

If a manager ignores your concerns, retaliates, or treats you unfairly, go up the chain: a general manager, owner, or HR. Document everything, and see Guides 03 and 06 for next steps.

CHAPTER 7

De-escalation: Calming a Heated Moment

When someone is already angry, whether it's a coworker, a manager, or a guest, your goal is to lower the temperature.

Do

- Keep your voice low and slow.
- Keep your body relaxed and non-threatening. Don't cross your arms or step closer.
- Acknowledge the emotion: "I can tell you're frustrated."
- Offer a next step: "Let's figure this out after the rush."

Don't

- Match their volume or tone.
- Say "Calm down." (It almost never works.)
- Argue about who's right in the moment.
- Bring up past issues.

Important: If anyone becomes physically threatening, remove yourself from the situation and get a manager or security immediately. Your safety comes first.

CHAPTER 8

Receiving and Giving Feedback

Receiving feedback

- Listen without interrupting, even if you disagree.
- Ask clarifying questions: "Can you give me an example?"
- Thank the person, then take time to think it over.
- If feedback feels unfair, respond calmly later, with specifics.

Giving feedback (as a coworker, trainer, or lead)

- Give it privately, and promptly.
- Be specific about the behavior, not the person.
- Include what's going well, too.
- Offer help: "Want me to show you how I do the closing checklist?"

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Conflict Resolution Planner

Use this before a hard conversation.

Who is the conflict with?

What exactly happened? (facts only)

How has it affected me or my work?

What might their side of the story be?

What outcome do I want?

My opening line:

My "I" statement (When..., I feel..., because..., Could we...):

Best time and place to talk:

If it doesn't go well, my next step:

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: After the Conversation

What went well:

What I'd do differently next time:

What we agreed on:

Follow-up date:

My communication style check

- I tend to avoid conflict (passive)
- I tend to react loudly or blame (aggressive)
- I tend to vent to others instead of addressing it (passive-aggressive)
- I'm working toward saying what I need clearly and respectfully (assertive)

One communication habit I want to change:

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Dealing with Being Outcasted and Treated Differently by Management

How to recognize unfair treatment, protect your confidence and income, and decide your next move

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- Signs you're being singled out
- Favoritism vs. discrimination vs. retaliation
- How to respond without making it worse
- Action plan and confidence-rebuilding worksheets

06

Self-check tools, response scripts, and a personal action plan

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Please note: This guide is general education, not legal advice. If you believe you are being treated differently because of your race, sex, age, religion, disability, national origin, pregnancy, or another protected characteristic, or because you reported a problem, consider speaking with an employment attorney or the appropriate government agency promptly, because deadlines apply.

CHAPTER 1

You're Not Imagining It

Being left out, singled out, or held to a different standard at work is painful. It can make you second-guess yourself, dread your shifts, and feel invisible to the people who control your schedule and income.

Many people in this position spend months wondering: *Is it me? Am I being too sensitive? Is this really happening?* This guide will help you look at what's happening clearly, protect yourself, and choose a path forward.

What being outcasted can look like

- You're scheduled for fewer or worse shifts than coworkers with similar experience.
- You get the slow or undesirable sections again and again.
- Rules are strictly enforced for you but not for others.
- You're left out of group chats, meetings, pre-shift information, or team events.
- Your manager is friendly with others but cold, short, or dismissive with you.
- You're criticized in public while others are corrected in private, or not at all.
- Your requests (time off, shift swaps, training) are denied while others' are approved.
- You're passed over for promotions, training, or better roles.
- Coworkers start distancing themselves after a manager's attitude toward you changes.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding What's Happening

Unfair treatment usually falls into one of a few categories. Knowing which it might be helps you choose the right response.

Favoritism

A manager prefers certain employees, often friends, long-time staff, or people who socialize with them. It's frustrating and unfair, but in many places favoritism alone is **not illegal** unless it's connected to something below. It may still violate company policy.

Discrimination

When you're treated worse **because of** a protected characteristic. Under U.S. federal law, these include race, color, religion, sex (including pregnancy, sexual orientation, and gender identity), national origin, age (40 and over), disability, and genetic information. Many states and cities protect additional characteristics.

Signs it may be discrimination:

- The people treated better tend to share a characteristic you don't.
- Comments or "jokes" about your background, accent, appearance, religion, age, or identity.
- Treatment changed after you shared something personal (a pregnancy, a disability, a religious practice).

Retaliation

When you're treated worse **because you** did something protected: reported harassment or discrimination, complained about wages or tips, raised a safety concern, took protected leave, or supported a coworker's complaint. Retaliation is illegal in many situations, even if the original complaint isn't proven.

Signs it may be retaliation:

- Treatment changed soon after you complained or reported something.
- Sudden write-ups, schedule cuts, or coldness with no other explanation.

Personality or communication clash

Sometimes a manager simply doesn't connect with you, or there's a misunderstanding that grew over time. This is still worth addressing, and a direct conversation may help (see Chapter 4).

Category	Is it illegal? (U.S. generally)	Best first step
Favoritism	Usually not, unless tied to a protected characteristic	Document; consider a conversation or going up the chain
Discrimination	Yes, under federal and many state laws	Document; report in writing; consider EEOC or an attorney
Retaliation	Often, depending on what you reported	Document the timeline; report; consider an attorney
Personality clash	No	Direct, calm conversation; ask for clear expectations

CHAPTER 3

Self-Check: Is It a Pattern?

Answer honestly. This isn't about proving anything. It's about seeing clearly.

- The different treatment has happened more than a few times
- I can point to specific examples with dates
- Coworkers in similar roles are treated differently in the same situations
- Other people have noticed or commented on it
- The treatment started or got worse after a specific event
- It's affecting my income (shifts, sections, hours)
- It's affecting my health, sleep, or confidence
- I've tried to address it and nothing changed

If you checked several boxes, it's time to start documenting, if you haven't already. **Guide 03** in this series walks you through exactly how to do it.

Compare treatment side by side

Use this to spot patterns objectively. Include coworkers with similar roles and experience.

Situation	How I was treated	How others were treated	Date(s)
Scheduling			
Section assignments			
Time-off requests			
Discipline / write-ups			
Training or promotion			
Daily communication			

CHAPTER 4

Responding Without Making It Worse

When you feel targeted, it's natural to want to push back hard or shut down completely. A calm, strategic approach protects you better.

Protect your professional record

- **Keep your performance strong.** Be on time, follow the rules, and do your side work. Don't give anyone a legitimate reason to discipline you.
- **Stay professional in writing.** Texts and emails can be shown to others later.
- **Don't vent about management on social media** or in group chats. It can be used against you.
- **Keep records** of your good work too: compliments from guests, sales numbers, positive feedback.

Consider a direct conversation

If you feel safe doing so, a calm conversation can sometimes change things. Keep it focused on facts and your goals.

Goal	What you can say
Understand scheduling	"I've noticed I've had fewer shifts than usual over the past month. Can you help me understand how shifts are being assigned and what I can do to get more?"
Address sections	"I'd love a chance at the main floor on weekends. What would you need to see from me to make that happen?"
Address tone	"I've felt some tension between us lately, and I want to fix it. Is there something I've done that we should talk about?"
Clarify expectations	"I want to make sure I'm meeting expectations. Could you share any specific feedback on my performance?"
Name the pattern	"I've noticed I'm being held to different rules than others on [specific issue]. I'd like to understand why."

After the conversation, send a short recap by text or email: "Thanks for talking with me today. Just to confirm, you said..."

Try this: Asking for clear, specific expectations is powerful. It either gives you a real path forward or creates a record that the standards are unclear or applied unfairly.

When a conversation isn't safe or doesn't work

- **Go up the chain:** a general manager, owner, district manager, or HR.
- **Put it in writing.** Guide 03 includes a written-complaint template.
- **Know your outside options:** if you believe you're facing discrimination or retaliation, government agencies like the EEOC or your state's civil rights or labor agency may be able to help, and **deadlines apply.**

CHAPTER 5

Protecting Your Confidence

Being singled out can slowly wear down how you see yourself. Protecting your self-worth is just as important as protecting your job.

Separate their behavior from your worth

How a manager treats you says more about the manager, the workplace, or the situation than about your value. You can take feedback seriously without accepting disrespect.

Build support outside of work

- Talk to friends or family who can remind you who you are outside of work.
- Connect with coworkers you trust, carefully, and without gossip.
- Consider talking to a counselor, especially if you're feeling anxious, depressed, or stuck.

Remind yourself of the facts

- Keep a **"wins" list**: great guest feedback, big sales nights, skills you've learned.
- Re-read it on hard days.

Watch for the signs it's getting to you

- Losing sleep or appetite over work
- Dreading every shift
- Feeling hopeless or worthless
- Pulling away from people you care about

If these sound familiar, please reach out for support. See Guide 02 in this series for burnout recovery tools. In the U.S., you can call or text **988** any time if you're in crisis.

CHAPTER 6

Deciding Your Next Move

You have more options than you may think. There's no single right answer. It depends on your finances, your goals, and how serious the situation is.

Option	When it may make sense
Stay and improve the relationship	It seems like a misunderstanding or clash, and a conversation helped
Stay and escalate	The treatment is serious, you want to keep the job, and you're documenting
Request a transfer	Your company has other locations or shifts with different management
Take outside action	You believe it's discrimination or retaliation and internal steps didn't work
Leave for a better workplace	The environment is harming you and you've found (or are building toward) a better option

If you decide to leave

- **Start your search while you're still employed**, if possible.
- **Keep copies** of your pay records and documentation before you leave. Only keep your own records, not confidential company information.
- **Give notice professionally** if it's safe to do so, and keep your exit calm.
- **Ask a trusted former coworker or supervisor** to be a reference.
- **Look for red flags and green flags** in your next workplace (see below).

Green flags in a new restaurant

- Clear, written policies for scheduling, sections, and tip-outs
- Managers who give feedback privately and respectfully
- Low turnover, with staff who have been there for years
- Fair ways to raise concerns, like HR or an owner who listens

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Action Plan

What's happening (in one or two sentences):

Which category it may fall into (favoritism, discrimination, retaliation, clash):

How it's affecting my income:

How it's affecting my well-being:

The outcome I want:

My next step (and date):

Who I will talk to (manager, HR, owner, attorney, agency):

My support people:

My backup plan if things don't improve:

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Wins List

Write down every win, big or small. Re-read it on the hard days.

Date	Win (guest compliment, big night, skill learned, goal met)

Three things I'm good at that no one can take away from me:

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You deserve a workplace that respects your time, your effort, and your dignity. Keep this guide close, share what helps, and look out for the people working beside you.

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